

HERO

Venith was now no ordinary man, for he carried a strange glow about him. No person could describe it, but he had an aura that flickered like a candle in the fog. The elders and the children felt a strange warmth when he was near, but he was a leader now, and those who followed him paid this no mind. He prayed, and when he prayed he spoke to Serna.

“Oh great and righteous one, oh mighty light, look upon me! For it is I who have always been your humble servant. I look upon my town and see the beggar starving, the children crying, the murderer lurking. Give me the power to help you, so that I may save my people.”

Now Serna did truly hear his squalid plea and gazed upon him. She saw the aura upon him, and it filled her with great hope. Venith had always prayed to her every day of every week, always offered gifts, helped the poor and needy, and punished the criminal. Serna was strong then, and when she looked upon Venith she saw not a servant but a soldier, a general. She did not see a candle in the fog, but a fire in the night, or the great sun that brings the day. He was a hero who would aid her in the times of peril to come. For peril was coming, and she needed allies. And so Serna gave away one of her powers to him: the power to turn hearts—the power to steady the trembling, to calm the wrathful, to mend the broken, to make the evil ones turn and see that they had wandered from the path.

Venith smiled at this gift, and then went to Terra.

— Spell, *Venith's Grand Lie*